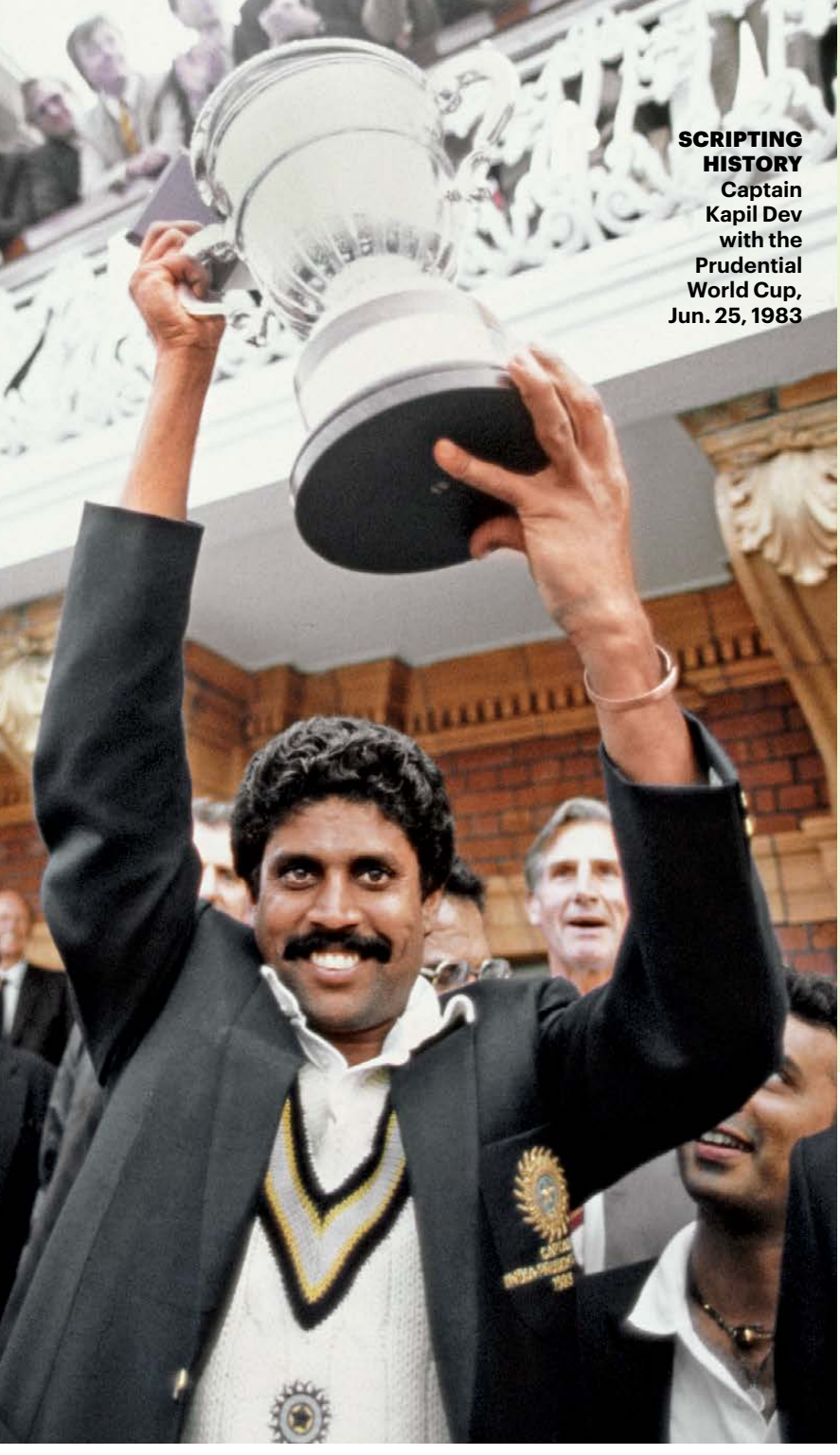


SCRIPTING HISTORY Captain Kapil Dev with the Prudential World Cup, Jun. 25, 1983

GETTY IMAGES

THE TIDAL EFFECT

» **Hockey was the national sport only notionally hereafter. Cricket was enshrined in the consciousness**

» **Money flowed in via sponsorships, TV rights. Player value rose manifold, infrastructure, academies bloomed**

» **Future stars like Sachin Tendulkar and M.S. Dhoni ensured that India stayed a cricketing power**

» **Our fanbase, local and diasporic, became an unmatched force in itself**

» **India soon became the economic hub of cricket—presaging the IPL era**

» **Under Dhoni, India finally brought back the ODI World Cup, in 2011. A 91 n.o. and the six to seal the win in the final made it a match for the ages**



DID YOU KNOW?

June 25 was the day India debuted in Test cricket—in 1932, also at Lord's, under C.K. Nayudu. Same date, same venue, 51 years later, came the real tryst with destiny

the same Lord's like "the crack of doom", with a fifer in our very first international inning. But India lost by 158 runs. The trough held for decades, barring eminent exceptions. By contrast, in the early '80s, Clive Lloyd's West Indies were in the midst of their imperious 'Pax Carribeana'—part of the proof were the 1975 and 1979 ODI World Cups. India had won just one match across both! Even the players packed for England as if for a holiday: no one gave India a snowflake's chance in hell.

Not even when they surprised themselves by reaching the final. Especially not then. This is where the cricket bled into India's psychological soil. The crack of dawn is often ascribed to the inspirational Kapil. But as a literal and metaphorical fact, it was a victory of the Little Men. An unsung Balwinder Sandhu cutting one 'up the hill' to snaffle Gordon Greenidge to turn the final towards its destination, Roger Binny swinging like a '20s jazzman, the doughty Yashpals and Madan Lals.... Fittingly, it democratised world cricket. In India, the game made its final passage from elite pastime to opium of the masses. From village to metropolis, we got a common source of pride. Academies bloomed. Newer stars spangled our sky. With time, India emerged as a global powerhouse, in viewership, revenues. When we won again in 2011, it was not as journeymen, but as lords at the centre of the cricket universe. ■

–with Amitabh Srivastava